praise from writer-director Anurag Kashyap, who placed it in the same league as acclaimed gangster dramas *Subramaniapuram* (2008, Tamil), *Angamaly Diaries* (2017, Malayalam) and *Vada Chennai* (2018, Tamil). "Stories are everywhere, but you need to tell them. Nothing travels or moves [you] like local stories," Raj said in an interview after *GGVV*'s release. He has also directed *Kantara*'s 'boota kola' scenes and worked on the dialogues for *777 Charlie*.

The three Shettys' simple beginnings reflect in their work. Rakshit, who used to work as an IT engineer in Bengaluru, grew up in Udupi and was a fan of the local 'Pilivesha' dance (tiger dance), which he drafted into his film as a recurring motif (Pilivesha also makes an appearance in *GGVV*). Similarly, Rishab was not even in his teens when he first put on make-up and a costume for the annual 'yakshagana' tradition in his village Keradi, in Kundapura. He credits it for teaching him about 'angika abhinaya' (expression through the medium of the body). "It was my introduction to the tales from the Ramayana and Mahabharata, and has had a huge influence on my acting." He would later do theatre, which strengthened his acting skills. Raj, who grew up in Mangaluru, studied social work before he started writing his own scripts. The first film, he told an interviewer, was written on a lonely stretch of the seashore in Mangaluru in the shade of a fishing boat.

Though Kannada films were being dubbed into Hindi and other languages earlier as well, the industry wasn't actively marketing its work to the national audience. In fact, Kannada cinema wasn't even recognised as an industry outside Karnataka, say Chaluve Gowda and Vijay Kiragandur of Hombale Films, which was set up in 2013. "We felt we can take the industry to the next level," they say. "It's not like we had no good actors or directors, or that our movies were not made in other languages. But nobody has tried to make content from Karnataka reach a global audience."

With *K.G.F.* and *Kantara*, the company has had two consecutive hits in less than six months. "Our intention isn't to take every film to the pan-India level," they say, adding that they instead intend to have one pan-India film a year. The banner currently has 14 films in the pipeline, including the Prabhas-starrer *Salaar*, a Malayalam film, *Dhoomam*, with actor Fahadh Faasil, and a Tamil film with Keerthy Suresh. Also on the cards is *Richard Anthony* (part two of *Ulidavaru Kandanthe*), with Rakshit both directing and starring.



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Hombale Films

IT'S ABOUT TEAMWORK

Collaboration between directors, producers, writers and actors in several new Kannada movies is a trend comparable to the Malayalam industry, says Bhashyam. "[But] it is new to Indian cinema."

The approach is rooted in sheer strategy. "When I made *Ulidavaru Kandanthe*, I thought people would rush to theatres," says Rakshit. When they didn't, he sought out new filmmakers to ensure a steady supply of cinema that would grow an audience. Since 2014, Rakshit has worked with several new directors, while his production house, Paramvah Studios, brought together a pool of writers—mostly friends—who went by the name The Seven Odds. It included Rishab and himself. "We need at least 10 filmmakers to be making at least 10 films a year because you cannot make just one film a year and say 'we're also catering to the class audience'," says Rakshit.

The formula seems to have worked. In 2016, *Kirik Party*, a college story written by Rakshit and directed by Rishab, became a smash hit. The film made nearly 10 times its budget of Rs 2.5 crore, says producer Pushkara Mallikarjunaiah. While it engaged audiences from non-Kannada-speaking regions, fans back home were already drawing parallels with the 1980s, the golden era of Shankar Nag. *Kirik Party* was an eclectic project, with music composer Ajaneesh Lokanath, who also wrote the score for *Kantara*, being a key presence. Rishab then went on to work on his own films, such as the National Award-winning *Sarkaari Hiriya Praathamika Shaale* (2018), and the detective-comedy *Bell Bottom* (2019), which gave him his first lead role.

Mallikarjunaiah says the current stream of box-office successes in Karnataka is a due culmination of the efforts over the past six years. "Rishab, coming from nowhere, made a Rs 300 crore film. It says that content is king. Film producers are confident that they can go ahead with good content and new actors."

As Rishab basks in the success of *Kantara*, he intends to stick to what he knows best: make films in Kannada. "Hindi-speaking audiences from various states liked a story from a village in coastal Karnataka. Do I have to change my storytelling for my next film? I don't think so... I have to, and will stick to, my roots," he says.

Going by the response to *Kantara*, perhaps that's what filmgoers want: raw, authentic local stories that stand out from the rest. ■